

The 6:15

THURSDAY · SEPTEMBER 24, 2026

NO. 18

THE BOARD

CALENDAR (NEXT 10 DAYS)

Today	Xi Jinping's first US state visit in 11 years — State Arrival Ceremony 10:00a ET, state dinner this evening; US-China trade truce already extended two months to Jan. 10 per Treasury Secretary Bessent [NEW] — see Politics/Geopolitics. Initial jobless claims: 193K vs. 215K expected, released this morning [NEW] .
Fri 9/25	Northwestern at No. 5 Indiana, Bloomington, 8:00p ET (FOX One) — see Sports.
Tue 9/29	Yankees host the AL Wild Card Series opener [carried from issue No. 17, not re-verified] .
Wed 9/30	August PCE price index (BEA), 8:30a ET — first inflation read since the Sept. 16 hike.
Thu 10/1	Nike fiscal Q1 2027 earnings, after the close; consensus not verified this run.
Wk of 9/28	Earnings cluster incl. Broadcom, Adobe, Oracle, Micron, Costco, Accenture, Dell, HPE, Kroger, Lennar, Jabil, Carnival, Medtronic [dates/consensus indicative, not individually verified] . FOMC next meets Oct. 27-28. OPEC+'s October JMMC date still not confirmed.

Durable goods, final Q2 GDP and existing home sales remain un-pinned to a primary BLS/BEA/Census date this run — continuity flag carried from issue No. 17.

METRICS · ET UNLESS NOTED

Oil	Divergent, not reconciled: Brent \$101.61 (+2.37% d/d, one tracker, Wed close) vs. a separate spot check at \$102.34 and a 10:00a intraday read of \$102.03; EIA's daily series shows \$114.89 for Tue 9/22, a clear outlier [flag] . WTI \$92.71 (+2.42% d/d, one tracker) — not independently confirmed by a second NYMEX settle; implies an unusually wide ~\$9 Brent-WTI spread if accurate [flag] .
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Rates	10Y 5.135% Wed close (intraday 5.104%-5.135%), highest since July 2007. 2Y 4.75% (Tue, one day stale). 30Y 5.30% (Tue) vs. 5.38% (Wed) — divergent.
Vol/FX/gold	DXY ~100.55 (Thu open, up from 99.98 Fri 9/18). VIX 14.53 (+1.47%). Gold \$4,308.35-\$4,338.05 — down from issue No. 17's \$4,415.90 record.
Equities	Wed close: Dow 51,511.59 (-0.68%/-352pts); S&P 500 7,706.03 (-0.75%); Nasdaq Comp. 26,936.04 (-1.13%). Futures Thu AM: S&P -0.4%, Nasdaq -0.5%. Asia (Wed): Nikkei ~65,018.95; Hang Seng -1.01% to 24,834.12; Shanghai Comp. -0.39% to 3,936.52. Europe not verified this run. Retail gas: AAA \$4.4744/gal natl. avg (Wed), up from \$4.4687 (Fri 9/18).

Crude: ICE Brent/NYMEX WTI front-month trackers and EIA. Rates: Fed H.15/CME-style trackers. Equities: exchange closes/CNBC-style quote pages.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Diplomacy	Two tracks: (1) Direct-ish US-Iran talks, NYC, Tue 9/22, three hours, Qatar-mediated (Witkoff/Kushner-Araghchi) — Iran TV says the meeting conveyed Tehran's conditions to reopen the strait: lift the naval blockade, release frozen assets, end the war on all fronts. No breakthrough; another meeting set "in the very near future" [NEW, multi-sourced] . (2) Iran-Oman temporary-corridor/mine-clearance framework (agreed ~Aug. 26) — still contingent on lapsed June interim-deal commitments; no Omani confirmation located this run [continuity] .
Transits	IMF PortWatch: just 1 transit recorded Sept. 20 vs. an 85/day pre-crisis baseline — worse than issue No. 17's already-low 8-transit Sept. 13 read. Separate Kpler window: 13/day 10-day average (early Sept.). PortWatch elsewhere: 7/day average since March. Three numbers, three windows, unreconciled.
Dark tankers/AIS	No fresher count this run; carrying the same split — ~80% of a trailing-two-week window AIS-off (one read) vs. ~57% of the full conflict period (peak 65.2% in May, another read).

War-risk premia	No fresher print located; carrying 7.5%-10% of hull value (~\$21M on a \$210M VLCC) from issues No. 16/17.
Saudi bypass	Aramco's East-West "Petrolina" pipeline (4M bpd capacity, Red Sea port of Yanbu) restarted ~Sept. 22 after a nine-day shutdown from Sept. 13 drone attacks; reduced rate, full restoration "could take weeks" [NEW] — the likely proximate driver of Wednesday's early oil-price relief.

Transit counts (vessels/day), the dark-fleet percentage, and the hull-value premia range measure different things over different windows — never netted or averaged.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Split a Tue. 9/22 doubleheader with Tampa Bay (W 2-0, L 1-6), then won 9-2 Wed. 9/23. Record computed at 91-67 through Wednesday — see Sports.
Knicks	No reported moves in the last 24 hours; 2026-27 preseason opens Oct. 5 at Philadelphia.
Northwestern	No moves since Saturday's win; at No. 5 Indiana Friday, 8:00p ET.

LEAD

RATES REPRICE HAWKISH

The hawkish repricing hits full stride — a 2007-high 10-year, a hot PMI, a claims beat, and rising odds of a second straight Fed hike

Three weeks ago the Federal Reserve, under new Chair Kevin Warsh, raised the federal funds rate a quarter point to 3.75%-4.00% — its first hike since July 2023, passed 12-0 on Sept. 16. [fact] This week the data caught up to the signal. Wednesday's S&P Global flash PMI showed the composite index at 58.4, up from 56.0 in August and the strongest private-sector expansion since July 2021; manufacturing jumped to 57.0 from 53.9 (consensus was 53.6), the best reading since May 2022; services rose to 58.7 from 56.5

(consensus 56.0), the fastest expansion in more than five years. [fact] New orders grew at their fastest pace in nearly four and a half years, and employment growth hit its highest level since February 2021. [fact] This morning's initial jobless claims added to the picture: 193,000 against a 215,000 consensus, with the 4-week moving average down to 207,000 and continuing claims (week ending Sept. 17) at 1,347,000 — a clean beat, on every measure, that argues against any near-term labor-market cooling. [NEW]

The bond market's reaction has been unambiguous. The 10-year Treasury yield closed Wednesday at 5.135%, its highest level since July 2007, having jumped more than 13 basis points intraday as the PMI print hit; the 5-year crossed 5% for the first time since 2007 in the same session. [fact] Markets are now pricing roughly 70% odds of another quarter-point hike at the Oct. 27-28 FOMC meeting, which would be back-to-back increases — a sharp reversal from where futures sat as recently as early 2026, when cuts were still the base case. [read] The Fed's own September dot plot pointed the same direction before this week's data arrived: the median participant projection has one more 2026 hike taking the funds rate to 4.10%, a flat 2027, and cuts not resuming until 2028-29. [fact] Core PCE — the Fed's preferred gauge — was already running at 3.3% as of the July read, up from 3.0% in December 2025; the August print lands Sept. 30, the first inflation data point since the hike and the next test of whether Wednesday's move was a one-print overreaction or the start of a trend. [fact/flag]

Equities took the yield move badly: the S&P 500 fell 0.75% Wednesday to 7,706.03, the Nasdaq Composite dropped 1.13% to 26,936.04, and the Dow lost 352 points (0.68%) to 51,511.59 — a session Yahoo Finance and others attributed directly to the PMI-

driven yield spike overwhelming any relief from Middle East diplomacy or the AI trade. [fact] Futures are pointing lower again Thursday morning (S&P -0.4%, Nasdaq -0.5%), with today's Trump-Xi summit adding a second live variable investors have to underwrite before the open. [fact] The mechanism worth sitting with: a hawkish Fed repricing that shows up first and hardest in the long end of the curve — the 10-year outpacing the 2-year's move — is a different regime than the 2022-23 hiking cycle, where front-end policy moves dominated. [read] If growth data keeps running hot into an economy already near full employment (the claims beat is one more data point for that), the term premium embedded in Wednesday's move has room to build further before the Sept. 30 print gives the market a cleaner read on whether the Fed is fighting a demand problem or a supply one. [read] For a portfolio priced off five-week-old cut expectations, that's the trade that just broke. [read]

One caveat worth carrying into the PCE print: the flash PMI's own price components suggest this is at least partly an inflation story rather than a pure growth story. Input costs across goods and services rose at the fastest pace since October 2022, driven by fuel, transport and wage pressures; selling-price inflation also picked up from August, though it stayed below the March-July rates. [fact] A hot composite driven partly by cost-push pressure feeding through supply chains is a different signal for the Fed than one driven by demand alone — worth distinguishing before assuming Wednesday's yield move is purely a "growth is strong" repricing. [read]

POLITICS

Xi Jinping landed at Joint Base Andrews Wednesday evening for his first state visit to the US in eleven years; Trump greeted him

planeside, reportedly the first time a US president has met a foreign leader at the airport in roughly six decades outside a papal visit. [NEW] Thursday's program: a South Portico greeting and State Arrival Ceremony at 10:00-10:10am ET with roughly 479 military personnel, a state dinner Thursday evening in the East Room with tech-industry CEOs among the guests, a military ceremony with jet flyovers, and a joint visit to the National Archives to view the Declaration of Independence and Constitution. [fact] Trump has previously called potential Taiwan arms sales "a very good negotiating chip," a framing worth watching given Taiwan's place on the agenda (see Geopolitics). [read] No litigation or reinstatement update was located this run on the CNN/Politico/MS NOW White House access restriction that took effect Sept. 20 (issue No. 17); it remains unresolved but carries no new movement. [continuity]

ECONOMICS

Beyond the PMI and claims data in the Lead, the forward calendar is what matters most from here: August PCE lands Sept. 30, the first inflation print since the Sept. 16 hike and the one the Oct. 27-28 FOMC will weigh most heavily. [fact] The Fed's own dot plot has already signaled one more 2026 hike to 4.10%, a pause through 2027, and cuts not resuming until 2028-29 — a materially more hawkish path than markets were pricing as recently as this spring. [fact] Composite input-cost inflation across the flash PMI survey hit its highest since October 2022 on fuel, transport and wage pressures, with services input costs at their highest since November 2022 specifically — a detail that argues the growth beat carries its own inflationary tax, not a clean signal of stronger real demand. [fact] The curve's reaction has been uneven by our sourcing: a 10-year at a 2007 high sits against 2-year and 30-year reads that diverge across

trackers checked this run (30Y 5.30% vs. 5.38% depending on source, 2Y a day stale at 4.75%) — directionally consistent with a broad-based selloff, but not clean enough to characterize the exact curve shape with confidence this morning. [flag]

BUSINESS

Saudi Aramco's East-West pipeline — 4M bpd of capacity that lets Saudi crude bypass the Strait of Hormuz entirely via the Red Sea port of Yanbu — restarted this week after a nine-day shutdown triggered by drone attacks on Sept. 13. [NEW] It's running at a reduced rate; one security source told Bloomberg full restoration to 4M bpd "could take weeks." [fact] The restart is the more concrete supply-side story behind Wednesday's early oil-price relief, ahead of the yield spike taking over as the session's dominant driver (see Lead). [read] Tech-industry CEOs are among tonight's state-dinner guests alongside Xi (see Politics) — attendee names were not independently confirmed this run, but the optic underscores how much of the summit's substance (rare earths, AI export controls) runs directly through US tech and semiconductor supply chains. [flag] Earnings season resumes in earnest next week: Nike reports fiscal Q1 2027 results after Thursday Oct. 1's close, with a cluster of large-caps — Broadcom, Adobe, Oracle, Micron, Costco, Accenture and others — reporting across the same window; individual dates and consensus figures were not independently verified this run and should be treated as indicative only. [flag]

GEOPOLITICS

The first concrete outcome of the Trump-Xi summit is already in: Treasury Secretary Bessent said this morning the US and China have agreed to extend their trade truce by two months, through Jan. 10, pushing back what had been a November expiration. [NEW, multi-sourced: CNBC, Bloomberg, Nikkei] The original truce dates to an October 2025 agreement; today's extension removes a near-term tariff-snapback risk investors had been pricing against a hard November deadline, though it is an extension of the status quo rather than a resolution of the underlying tariff, rare-earth-export and technology-control disputes. [read] Beyond the truce, previews across multiple outlets converge on critical minerals, technology controls and Taiwan as the summit's other top agenda items; Iran and Ukraine are also expected to come up, though neither is expected to produce a deliverable from this specific meeting. [fact] The South China Sea and Korean peninsula round out the expected agenda, with no outcome reported on either as of this morning's press time. [flag] Separately, no fresh Ukraine/Sumy development was located this run beyond what issue No. 17 already carried — that thread was not re-searched this cycle and is not repeated here pending new information. [continuity]

IRAN & HORMUZ

Tuesday's three-hour, Qatar-mediated New York meeting between US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner and Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi is the most direct US-Iran contact reported since the war began in February — even though it was conducted through intermediaries rather than face to face. [NEW] Iranian state

television framed it as Tehran laying out conditions for reopening the strait: lifting the naval blockade, releasing frozen Iranian assets, and ending the war "on all fronts" — a maximalist opening position, not an agreed framework. [read] Trump called the session "very productive" and said a follow-up meeting is coming soon; no breakthrough was announced, and none of the numbers in this issue's Hormuz counters (transits, dark-fleet share, premia) show any change yet that would corroborate progress. [flag] That keeps this diplomatically separate from the Iran-Oman corridor track, which remains where issue No. 17 left it: agreed in principle in August, contingent on US compliance with a lapsed interim deal, and still without on-record Omani confirmation of any near-term reopening. [continuity] Worth noting the scale mismatch between diplomacy and physical supply: Tehran's opening conditions (naval blockade lifted, assets unfrozen, war ended "on all fronts") describe a full settlement, while the actual near-term relief to global crude flows this week came from a single Saudi pipeline restart, not from any Hormuz-specific breakthrough (see Board and Business). [read] The market's own pricing — a still-elevated 7.5%-10% war-risk premium, no fresher transit or dark-fleet data confirming any change in the strait itself — treats Tuesday's talks as exactly what they were: a conversation, not a resolution. [read]

SPORTS

Yankees

Split Tue. doubleheader with Tampa Bay (W 2-0, L 1-6), won 9-2 Wed. (Cole W; Rice HRs No. 40 & 41; McMahon grand slam). 91-67 through Wed. by our game-log count; clinched a playoff berth Sept. 14; wild-card seeding not independently confirmed this run.

Knicks

No reported moves in the last 24 hours. Preseason opens Oct. 5 at Philadelphia; defending NBA champions.

Northwestern

2-0, no game since Saturday's 41-7 win over Colorado. At No. 5 Indiana Friday 9/25, 8:00p ET (FOX One).

Gap notice. No issue ran Mon 9/21-Wed 9/23; items that moved across that window are tagged [NEW] rather than compared only to issue No. 17 (Sun 9/20).

Continuity. Not refreshed this run: Ukraine/Sumy developments, the Russia sanctions-bill signing status, the Salalah multilateral-meeting reschedule, and OPEC+'s exact October JMMC date — all carried as still-open from issue No. 17 without new search. The CNN/Politico/MS NOW White House access restriction remains unresolved with no update located. Watch for next issue: the outcome of today's Trump-Xi summit; the Aug. PCE print (Sept. 30) and its effect on Oct. 27-28 hike odds; whether the Brent/WTI and 2Y/30Y source divergence flagged today resolves to a single settle; and any Omani confirmation of the Iran-Oman corridor.

Unverified figures are marked in red: Brent/WTI settles, the 2Y/30Y pair, European closes, Wild Card scheduling, Yankees wild-card seeding, and week-of-9/28 earnings dates/consensus. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.